

Excel sheets, photo editing, and more. In GPU Benchmarks, once again, the Samsung Galaxy M34 showed off its dominance scoring higher than the OnePlus Nord CE 3 Lite in both 3D Mark Wild Life and GFXBench tests. The Galaxy M34 beat the iQOO Z7 in 3D Mark Wild Life but the iQOO Z7 slipped slightly ahead in GFXBench tests. Overall though, this proved to be a beast of a phone in the sub ₹20K price segment; excelling at both CPU and GPU benchmarks. However, in storage benchmarks, the Galaxy M34 falls behind since it is using the older UFS 2.2 memory standard, so transfer speeds won't be as fast as the iQOO Z7 or OnePlus Nord CE 3 Lite.

In real life, the phone is smooth and fluid in day-to-day tasks with no lag whatsoever. 120 Hz refresh rate makes actions such as scrolling between screens feel even more fluid and seamless. Gaming is also stutter-free on the Galaxy M34 on Medium Graphics at High Frame Rate. We played COD: Mobile for over half an hour and didn't face any major frame drops, however, the phone did heat up slightly. In the CPU Throttling Test, the phone got a great result – it throttled to merely 85 per cent of its peak performance, so it can sustain heavy workloads without throttling too much.

Moving on to software, the Samsung Galaxy M34 comes with Android 13 out of the box with Samsung's OneUI 5.1 skin on top. OneUI has plenty of features and customisations, and the overall aesthetic is pretty decent as well but it is rife with bloatware in the form of Samsung or third-party preinstalled apps. There's also the annoying Glance feature that shows up on the lock screen. You can disable it, but it's hidden deep in Settings under Wallpaper Services.

The best thing about the latest Samsung phones is the updates cycle where the company even has Google beat! The phone promises a whopping 4 years of OS updates and 5 years of security updates, which is fantastic.

CAMERA

The Samsung Galaxy M34 5G packs a triple rear camera stack consisting of a

50 MP primary camera with OIS (Optical Image Stabilization) support, an 8 MP ultrawide shooter, and a 2 MP macro camera. The primary camera usually snaps detailed photos in daylight or bright indoor light with vibrant colours and decent dynamic range. The camera tends to prioritise highlights and sometimes crushes shadows in the process though.

Close-up shots look great with a natural-looking bokeh effect. There are some instances when these shots can get a bit soft, usually when the light levels are not adequate. Portrait photos look good but if you look closely, the phone doesn't do a great job cutting out subjects' hair. There's also a strand or two that it misses out on entirely.

The 8 MP ultrawide shooter clicks good images with similar colour science to the main lens, but there's some loss of detail in the corners. Dynamic range is still decent, with instances of shadows being crushed. There's a token 2 MP macro lens that clicks acceptable shots – there's not a whole lot of detail but the results are usable, at least.

For selfies, the Samsung Galaxy M34 5G brings a 13 MP lens that clicks natural-looking selfies (if you turn off Beauty Mode) with good colour and detail retention. Portrait mode selfies look the same, but the edge detection could be improved.

Samsung has also introduced the Nightography feature in the budget segment with the Galaxy M34; a feature that is usually only available on Samsung's higher-end models. It allows you to take brighter pictures in low light but I still feel like the low-light photography could be improved on this phone. The dynamic range is not the best and some images appear very soft.

BATTERY LIFE

Equipped with a monstrous 6,000 mAh battery, the Samsung Galaxy M34 5G is a phone that can last most users two days without having to reach for the charger. To reach for the charger, you would first need to purchase one since the retail box skimps out on a charging adapter. The phone supports 25 W wired charging, with no support

for reverse wired charging or wireless charging. In our 4K video loop test, the Samsung Galaxy M34 lasted an astounding 21.5 hours! That's almost twice as much as the OnePlus Nord CE 3 Lite! Fifteen minutes of playing Call of Duty: Mobile only drained the battery levels by 3 per cent, and that should show you just about how power-efficient this device is. If battery life is your primary concern, and your budget is below ₹20,000, then this phone is a no-brainer. However, do note that 25 W charging in 2023 is quite slow. The device charged from empty to full in a little over 2 hours.

VERDICT

The Samsung Galaxy M34 gets a lot of the basics of a smartphone right. You get speedy performance, astoundingly good battery life, and a decent primary camera that should cover all your basic needs. Priced below ₹20,000, the Samsung Galaxy M34 offers great bang for your buck and stands strong in the face of competition. Its battery life is near unparalleled, and if that is your primary concern when buying a smartphone, don't hesitate to buy it. There are a few misses though – the dynamic range of the primary and ultrawide lens could be better, there's no HDR support on the display, there's plenty of preinstalled bloatware, and the teardrop notch looks extremely dated at this price in 2023. But if you're willing to overlook these nit-picks, the Samsung Galaxy M34 is a steal deal. An easy to recommend product for most individuals!

–Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Exynos 1280 | Manufacturing process: 5 nm | Storage: 128 GB | RAM: 6 GB | Display size and type: 6.5-inches, Super AMOLED | Refresh rate: 120 Hz | Display resolution: 1080 x 2400 pixels (FHD+) | Cameras (rear): 50 MP OIS camera + 8 MP ultrawide + 2 MP macro | Selfie camera: 13 MP | Speaker: Mono, Dolby Atmos | Battery capacity: 6,000 mAh | Charging: 25 W wired

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